

GRADE 8 · READING LITERATURE · RL.8.9

The Last Bakery on Cedar Street

Analyze how a modern story draws on a traditional story pattern, such as the underdog-versus-giant pattern found in myths and traditional stories, and describe how the modern version renders that pattern new.

Lesson Map · Passage · Guided · Partner · Independent Practice · Small Group · Answer Key

What You Will Learn Today

Learning Goals

Understand RL.8.9: Analyze how a modern story draws on a traditional story pattern, such ...

Read an original passage closely

Support every answer with text evidence

Work through guided, partner, and independent practice

How the Lesson Runs

Warm-up and passage

Guided practice together

Partner discussion

Independent + small-group work

Exit ticket and answer key

Unpacking the Standard

Many traditional stories share recognizable patterns: an outmatched underdog facing an overwhelming opponent, a trickster outwitting someone more powerful, a flood that washes away an old world to make room for a new one. A modern story can draw on one of these patterns while "rendering it new" — changing the setting, the stakes, or the resolution so it no longer resembles a retelling, but still carries the shape and meaning of the original pattern.

Modeled Example

The ancient story of David and Goliath features a young, poorly armed shepherd defeating a heavily armored giant using a slingshot and a single stone. What is the core pattern of this story, stripped of its specific details?

The core pattern is an underdog, seemingly powerless against a vastly stronger opponent, winning through an unconventional method rather than matching the opponent's own strength.

If a modern story used this same underdog pattern but replaced the giant with a corporation and the slingshot with a social media campaign, would it still be "drawing on" the original pattern? Explain.

Yes — the specific details (giant, slingshot) have changed entirely, but the underlying pattern (an overmatched underdog defeating a powerful opponent through an unconventional, clever method rather than brute force) remains intact, which is what "drawing on" a pattern means.

The Last Bakery on Cedar Street (Part 1)

1. Rosa Delgado had run Delgado's Bakery on Cedar Street for twenty-two years, long enough to have baked the wedding cakes of couples who now brought their own children in for Saturday morning pan dulce. When BreadGiant, a national chain with over four thousand locations, announced it was opening a store two blocks away, offering loaves at half her price, Rosa did the math on a napkin and did not like the number she got.

2. BreadGiant's regional director, in a local news interview, called Rosa's bakery "a quaint transition period" the neighborhood would move past within a year. He was not being cruel, exactly — he seemed to genuinely believe it, the way someone believes water will eventually fill any container it is poured into, without malice, simply because that is what water does.

3. Rosa did not have four thousand locations, a regional marketing budget, or the ability to sell bread below her own cost the way a company with warehouses full of capital could afford to, for a while, to starve out a competitor. What she had was twenty-two years of birthdays, funerals, and Tuesday mornings where she remembered exactly how a customer took their coffee.

The Last Bakery on Cedar Street (Part 2)

4. Rosa did not lower her prices to compete, and she did not run advertisements. Instead, she started a Tuesday night bread-making class in the back of the shop, free for anyone who signed up, teaching neighborhood kids and retirees alike how to shape a proper baguette. She could not out-market BreadGiant's multi-million-dollar campaign, but she could put her hands directly into two dozen people's lives every week, one loaf at a time.

5. Word of the classes spread the way small things spread in a neighborhood that still talked to itself: not through an algorithm, but through people telling other people. Six months in, a dozen former students had started baking their own bread at home instead of buying anyone's — including, unexpectedly, three of them who now volunteered to help Rosa on her busiest mornings, unpaid, simply because they wanted her shop to survive.

6. BreadGiant's location closed eleven months after opening, a quiet, unremarked failure buried in a corporate quarterly report under "underperforming regional assets." Rosa never mentioned it to her customers, and neither did the sign in her window, which still read, as it had for twenty-two years, simply: OPEN.

The Last Bakery on Cedar Street (Part 2), continued

7. She had not out-priced a company with four thousand locations, and she had not out-marketed its regional budget. She had done something a spreadsheet could not easily measure: made twenty-two Tuesdays feel like they belonged to the people who kept showing up, one loaf, one lesson, one remembered coffee order at a time.

Warm-up · Before You Read

1. What explicit detail does paragraph 1 give about how long Rosa has run her bakery?
2. What explicit threat does paragraph 1 introduce, and what specific competitive advantage does it have?

Guided Practice

3. Compare Rosa's and BreadGiant's resources as explicitly listed in paragraph 3. What core pattern does this comparison establish?

4. Identify the traditional story pattern this modern story draws on, and name the specific ancient story mentioned in the lesson that shares this pattern.

Guided Practice

5. In the traditional pattern, the underdog often wins using an unconventional method rather than matching the opponent's own strength. What unconventional method does Rosa use instead of lowering prices or advertising, according to paragraph 4?

6. How does Rosa's method in paragraph 4 mirror the "unconventional weapon" part of the underdog pattern (like the sling and stone in the original story) while still being entirely new?

Partner Discussion

7. What explicit detail from paragraph 5 shows the bread-making classes having a real effect on the neighborhood?

8. How does the detail of former students becoming unpaid volunteers develop the underdog pattern beyond simply "the small business survived"?

Partner Discussion

9. What explicit outcome does paragraph 6 state about BreadGiant's location?

Independent Practice

10. How does the phrase "quiet, unremarked failure buried in a corporate quarterly report" in paragraph 6 render the traditional giant-defeat scene new, compared to a dramatic physical battle in an ancient story?

11. What explicit detail from paragraph 6 shows that Rosa does not treat the outcome as a triumphant victory?

Independent Practice

12. How does Rosa's lack of a triumphant reaction in paragraph 6 depart from how an underdog's victory is often portrayed in traditional versions of this story pattern?

13. Explain how paragraph 7's final sentence ("made twenty-two Tuesdays feel like they belonged to the people...") redefines what "winning" means in this modern version of the pattern.

Independent Practice

14. Identify at least two specific ways this story "renders new" the traditional underdog-versus-giant pattern, rather than simply retelling it with different character names.

15. If this story had ended with Rosa's bakery closing instead of BreadGiant's, would it still be drawing on the same traditional pattern? Explain your reasoning.

Small-Group Work

16. What explicit comparison does paragraph 2 make to explain the regional director's belief that Rosa's bakery is temporary?

17. How does this water comparison in paragraph 2 characterize BreadGiant as a "giant" figure differently than a traditional giant character might be portrayed?

Small-Group Work

18. What explicit detail in paragraph 3 explains specifically how BreadGiant could afford to sell bread at half price, something Rosa could not do?

19. Why is the detail about BreadGiant's ability to sell below cost, in paragraph 3, important context for understanding why Rosa could not simply compete on price?

Exit Ticket

20. Explain how the ending detail that Rosa "never mentioned" BreadGiant's closure to her customers (paragraph 6) reinforces what her true goal seems to have been throughout the story.

Answer Key (1 of 4)

1. Twenty-two years, long enough that she baked wedding cakes for couples who now bring their own children into the shop.
2. BreadGiant, a national chain with over four thousand locations, opens two blocks away offering loaves at half Rosa's price.
3. Rosa has twenty-two years of personal relationships and memory; BreadGiant has four thousand locations, a marketing budget, and the ability to sell below cost — this establishes the underdog-versus-giant pattern, an individual facing an overwhelming, resource-rich opponent.
4. The underdog-versus-giant pattern, shared with the story of David and Goliath, where a much weaker figure faces a vastly more powerful opponent.
5. She starts a free Tuesday night bread-making class, building direct relationships with the community instead of competing on price or marketing.

Answer Key (2 of 4)

6. Like the sling and stone, her method does not match the giant's own strength (money, scale) at all; instead of a physical weapon, her "unconventional weapon" is community connection and skill-sharing, rendering the ancient pattern in a completely modern, nonviolent form.

7. A dozen former students started baking their own bread at home, and three began volunteering unpaid to help Rosa during busy mornings.

8. It shows the community actively fighting alongside the underdog rather than just passively rooting for her, deepening the pattern into one where the underdog's unconventional method turns bystanders into allies.

9. It closed eleven months after opening, described in a corporate report as an "underperforming regional asset."

10. Instead of a dramatic, visible defeat, BreadGiant's loss is bureaucratic and nearly invisible, reflecting how modern institutional "giants" are more likely to fail quietly through spreadsheets and closures than through a single decisive, visible clash.

Answer Key (3 of 4)

11. She never mentions the closure to her customers, and her shop's sign still simply reads "OPEN," as it had for twenty-two years, without any change to mark the win.

12. Traditional underdog stories often end with a clear, celebrated moment of triumph; Rosa's quiet, unchanged response reframes victory as continuity rather than conquest, a modern departure from the pattern's usual dramatic climax.

13. It redefines winning not as defeating the giant directly, but as strengthening the community bonds the giant could never replicate — a modern, relationship-based version of victory rather than a purely competitive one.

14. It replaces physical combat with community-building as the "weapon," and it replaces a dramatic, publicly celebrated victory with a quiet, almost invisible one (the corporate closure, the unchanged sign) — both choices update the pattern's meaning for a modern, non-violent, community-centered context rather than simply relabeling an old story.

15. It could still reference the same pattern by contrast, showing what happens when the underdog does not find an effective unconventional method, but it would no longer fulfill the pattern's traditional meaning of triumph through cleverness or community rather than strength, since that outcome depends on the underdog succeeding.

Answer Key (4 of 4)

16. He is compared to someone who believes water will eventually fill any container it is poured into "without malice, simply because that is what water does," suggesting he sees BreadGiant's expansion as an inevitable, impersonal force rather than a deliberate attack.

17. Unlike a traditional giant who is often portrayed as menacing or deliberately cruel, BreadGiant's giant-like power is portrayed as impersonal and almost mechanical, an update that reflects how modern institutional power can operate without any individual person intending harm.

18. It has warehouses full of capital, allowing it to sell below its own cost for a period of time specifically to drive out a competitor.

19. It clarifies that Rosa's disadvantage is not a lack of effort or skill but a structural financial disadvantage; only a company with vast reserved capital can sustainably lose money on individual sales, which explains why price competition was never a realistic option for her.

20. It reinforces that her goal was never really to defeat BreadGiant specifically, but to keep serving and connecting with her community; the closure is almost incidental to her, a byproduct of her real focus rather than a victory she needed to announce.

Exit Ticket

Answer on a sticky note

Answer the exit-ticket question from today's lesson.

Cite at least one piece of evidence from the passage.

Remember

Name your claim or answer

Quote or cite the evidence

Explain how it supports your answer